

Praying in Tongues to Agape Love

We are going to look at love in 1 Corinthians 13. I want you to notice the description Paul gives beginning with the fourth verse. This is a description of agape, not phileo.

Agape is the God kind of love.

At first, Jesus said from the Old Testament, "Love your neighbor as yourself." That was good for them because they were not born again. That is phileo. I can pretty much love you as myself, which means anything I do for you will only benefit you if it benefits me, because I can only love you to the degree I love myself.

But when we came into the New Covenant, Jesus said:

A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you.

That takes us from phileo into agape.

Here is the perfect description of agape:

Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up,
Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil;
Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth;
Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things.
Charity never faileth.

Charity is love in action. It is agape. It is love that does not refrain. It is a love that is always giving of itself.

This word charity does not mean getting your wrinkled, dirty suits and bringing them down to the outreach because Jesus said, "Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these, ye have done it unto Me." Jesus wants to thank you for that suit.

Charity, love in action, suffers long and is kind. It envies not. It vaunts not itself. It is not puffed up with pride. It does not behave itself unseemly. It seeks not its own. It seeks no recompense or reward for services rendered.

When Paul said, "Owe no man any thing, but to love one another," that is one debt you will never cancel in this covenant. Jesus puts you in debt to your fellow man for love. It does not matter how many payments you make on it, you will never pay that debt off.

I do not have to owe you money, but I will always be in debt to you for love.

Someone says, "But they treated me badly five times last week, and I responded in agape."

Thank you very much. Next week they will put you in debt again, and you will respond the same way, because this is a love that seeks not its own.

It is not easily provoked. Aren't you glad it says "not easily"? That is tough enough.

It thinks no evil. It rejoices not in iniquity, but rejoices in the truth.

You know how iniquity can work. Somebody does not quite believe like you do and says something about you. Then they fall to some disease, and you say, "Yep, they got what was coming to them. Should we call fire down from heaven?"

You are of the wrong spirit. Jesus said, "You know not what manner of spirit ye are of."

This is a description of agape. Then Paul says it never fails. That means no destroyer can come into your camp and do anything about this kind of love.

There is just one problem. When we teachers get up and teach on this, we outline agape and how you should walk in it, but I do not know anybody actually walking in the fullness of it. I do not think I know one single person.

As teachers, we have jumped in and outlined agape. What we missed are the necessary steps in the Spirit by which He takes you from glory to glory into the express image of Jesus Christ. We were so busy jumping ahead and outlining the nature of agape that we missed the five different steps it takes to finally be delivered to this agape.

Do I know anybody taking those five steps? Not many. I do not know many who are even taking the first one.

If we are going to understand these steps, we have to back up to 1 Corinthians 12:1:

Now concerning spiritual gifts, brethren, I would not have you ignorant.

Thank God that makes us even, because if there is any area I do not want to be ignorant in, it is concerning spiritual gifts.

Paul goes on:

Ye know that ye were Gentiles, carried away unto these dumb idols, even as ye were led.

Wherefore I give you to understand, that no man speaking by the Spirit of God calleth Jesus accursed: and that no man can say that Jesus is the Lord, but by the Holy Ghost.

He is saying, "You Corinthians were Gentiles following dumb idols that could not speak. Now you are serving the living God, and He has a voice. These are some of the rules that govern His voice."

To call Jesus accursed means to say that when He died on the Cross, He was actually being punished because He was lawless, that He truly died under the curse of the Cross as one guilty of it. Paul gives guidelines that no one moving by the Spirit of God will say that.

Then Paul talks in detail about the nine gifts of the Spirit and how the nine gifts empower the eight operations of God. The eight operations are qualified by whatever gifts of the nine operate in them.

Beginning in verse 27, Paul lists these eight operations:

Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.

And God hath set some in the church, first apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers, after that miracles, then gifts of healings, helps, governments, diversities of tongues.

I am an individual member in the Body of Christ, and every one of us is called to fill one or more of these eight operations.

The nine gifts empower and qualify these eight operations, and the eight operations come into existence in divine order. First apostles, secondarily prophets, thirdly teachers; after that miracles and gifts of healings; then helps and governments; and finally the prayer ministries of the eighth operation, diversities of tongues.

When Paul begins to exhort on this, he asks:

Are all apostles? are all prophets? are all teachers? are all workers of miracles?

Have all the gifts of healing? do all speak with tongues? do all interpret?

Are all apostles? No. All nine gifts of the Spirit qualify the apostle's office, but all are most definitely not apostles.

Are all prophets? No. Most people who think they are prophets are not. If you have to tell me you are a prophet, moving right along.

Are all teachers? No. You can tell that by the people sleeping in some services.

Are all workers of miracles? Certainly not in the empowerment of evangelism. Have all gifts of healings? No. All believers are called to lay hands on the sick and see them recover, but not all have a ministry of healings that heals the soul and body.

There are ministries of healings that touch the soul, such as ecstatic joy. Dry people come into a service, people whose fellowship with God is so dry that when they breathe it looks like powder on their face. The next thing you know, they are rolling off their chairs laughing, and their children are looking at them saying, "My dad has never done that." They are getting healed in their soul.

Do all have gifts of healings that go from the soul to the body? No.

Then Paul says, "Do all speak with tongues? Do all interpret?"

I wish Paul had worded that differently. What he is saying here is one thought: do all speak with a tongue in a public assembly to be interpreted? No. He is talking about a ministry-level gift.

Many times you will hear me pray in tongues while I am ministering, and He will pull revelation up right behind it. I can minister much more accurately to people when He uses me that way, or in prophecy.

But the gift of prophecy is more of an exhortation and preaching gift that whittles away people's resistance until they run to the altar. Tongues and interpretation can operate one-on-one as He pulls revelation out, or in a public assembly when God wants to say something from His mind.

When Paul says, "Do all speak with tongues? Do all interpret?" he is not talking about every believer speaking with tongues when filled with the Holy Ghost. That is tongues for personal edification.

Just as every believer is called to lay hands on the sick, but not every believer has workings of miracles and gifts of healings, every believer is called to be filled with the Holy Ghost and speak with tongues for personal edification, even though not every believer has the public gift of tongues and interpretation.

Paul says:

But covet earnestly the best gifts: and yet shew I unto you a more excellent way.

The word covet is very strong. In the Ten Commandments it says, "Thou shalt not covet." But here Paul reverses it and uses it positively. It is as strong as going without food and wanting one thing: food, food, food.

What are the best gifts? The best gifts are the ones that qualify your calling.

If I am called to be a mighty apostle, then to covet the best gifts means to covet all nine. If I am called to an evangelistic miracle ministry, then the best gifts would include workings of miracles, gifts of healings, and words of knowledge. The best gifts are the gifts among the nine that go with your calling, if you know what your calling is.

Then Paul says, "Yet I show unto you a more excellent way."

There should not have been a chapter break between 1 Corinthians 12 and 13. It should have been the same chapter.

When I found out that fasting was not so bad, that you just get hungry to a certain degree and weak to a certain degree and then it stops there until you die, I relentlessly coveted. I pressured God. I pursued Him.

Then God started turning the tables on me and said, "The rest of what you need is perfected in you as you love one another."

Barely is the love of God perfected in you as you love one another.

I thought, "God, can't You leave people out of it? I can do a real good job loving You, but do I really have to love people?"

The last stretch, the last mile, is perfected in a person as he loves one another.

I knew how to pursue God in fasting and prayer. Now Paul says to covet earnestly the best gifts, yet he will show me a more excellent way. A more excellent way to do what? To pursue God relentlessly for His presence and glory.

What is the more excellent way? This is why chapters 12 and 13 should not have been separated.

Paul begins 1 Corinthians 13:

Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal.

He is saying that even if I have been filled with the Holy Ghost and can talk with tongues, but I do not use that gift to edify myself and do not make it to agape love, I can still be a hater, full of strife, emulations, heresies, and problems.

You know I am telling the truth. Some people can speak with tongues and still be full of hatred and strife.

So the more excellent way is to pursue the love of God in the transformation of my character. The more excellent way is to pursue God for agape as fervently as I would pursue His power, His glory, and His ministry.

It is actually the shortcut to God's power.

If you only pursue God for His glory and power, how do I know your motives are not selfish, that you simply want Him to exalt you in front of people? But if you pursue agape, to love humanity with the love of God, you will never be hindered in your pursuit of God.

Agape is the more excellent way, and it is the shortcut to God's power. When compassion begins to love people, the next thing you need is the power of God to meet their needs.

Why did Paul mention tongues first? Because he is about to introduce the five steps that will deliver you to agape.

The first step is this:

Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels...

That means though I have the capability of speaking with tongues, though I go to church and warm my chair every Sunday, though I have been filled with the Holy Ghost and am definitely Pentecostal, I can still cause more trouble than three pastors can patch up.

Some of you have been tongue talkers for a long time, and you know at times you are out of control. How can you do that and still have the Holy Ghost? Easy. He dives into the new nature of your spirit and will not even come out until you get through.

The first step in these five steps is that I must be filled with the Holy Ghost.

In 1 Corinthians 12, Paul begins with the mighty apostle and goes down eight operations: apostle, prophet, teacher, workings of miracles, gifts of healings, helps, governments, and finally the prayer ministries of diversities of tongues.

Then in chapter 13, he begins with the last operation, diversities of tongues, and reverses the process. He builds you back up to the mighty mountain-moving faith of the apostle and the love of the same.

All the other seven operations rest on the foundation of diversities of tongues. Why? Because that is the operation of the gifts of the Spirit you and I received simultaneous with our rebirth.

I wish I had the mighty workings of miracles the moment I was born again, but it did not start operating then. I wish I had the mighty gift of prophecy the moment I was born again, or the teaching gift, but those did not start operating then. They may have been resident in the Holy Spirit, but I was not developed in them yet.

The one operation you can operate in simultaneous with your rebirth is diversities of tongues, specifically tongues for personal edification.

Jude says:

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

Building up where? If you are so called, up through the other seven operations. The edification process begins and builds you past helps and governments, pastor, evangelist, workings of miracles, gifts of healings, teacher, prophet, and apostle, according to your call.

Even within diverse tongues, I cannot interpret tongues anytime I want. It is as God wills. If interpretation were automatic, why would Paul say that if there is no interpreter, the man should speak to himself and to God?

Tongues as a sign to the unbeliever is when God suddenly drops an anointing on you, transcends your intellect, and allows you to preach, teach, or testify in a language you had no previous knowledge of. If I suddenly preached a whole message in Ugandan and people asked, "What did you say?" I would say, "I do not know. The Holy Ghost transcended my intellect."

That is tongues as a sign to the unbeliever.

Deep intercessional groanings of tongues bring you over to stand in the gap for the lost. I wish I could operate in that anytime I want, but I cannot.

There is only one diversity I can operate in at my will anytime: tongues for personal edification.

All the other nine gifts of the Spirit flow through you for the edification of others. There is one that flows to you for your own edification, and that is tongues for personal edification, the prayer language.

God has made me captain of my own ship. I can be as edified as I want because I am the steward of that operation. I can pray as long as I want, when I want, where I want, because I am the captain of my own ship when it comes to how edified I want to be.

Paul says:

Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal.
And though I have the gift of prophecy...

Praying in tongues will deliver you to the gift of prophecy, which equals tongues and interpretation. Somehow, praying in tongues delivers me to the first level of being used in tongues and interpretation or the gift of prophecy.

Then Paul says:

...and understand all mysteries...

Praying in tongues will deliver me to the understanding of mysteries.

This is what 1 Corinthians 14:2 means:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

What mysteries? The mysteries hidden in God since before the foundations of the world, now made available to the great Church of God, the born-again Church of grace: the mystery of Christ in you, the hope of glory.

When I pray in tongues, I begin to understand the mystery of everything Christ is in me, the hope of glory.

That is why Paul said:

I thank my God, I speak with tongues more than ye all.

He prayed more than all the Corinthians in the language that encompasses the understanding of the mysteries of Christ. God answered those prayers, and that is why Paul recorded the epistles with understanding.

The more you pray, the more you will pick up what is recorded in those epistles. You will become solid.

The next level is knowledge. The difference between mysteries and knowledge is this: when I pray the mystery of healing before God, He answers that prayer, and suddenly I have a full revelation of healing. I file that in the library. Then I pray the mystery of righteousness, and God answers. Now I know about righteousness, and I file it in the library. Then the mystery of prosperity, then agape. Pretty soon all these mysteries I have prayed are stored in a library on the inside of my spirit.

Now I can say, "Though I understand mysteries and have knowledge." I am no longer operating in head knowledge. The Word is being worked in me through mysteries and knowledge by the power of the Spirit.

That delivers me to the next level:

...and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains...

This is no longer mental assent. This is real faith that works, mountain-moving faith.

Then Paul moves to agape giving:

And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor...

And:

...though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing.

It takes mountain-moving faith to have agape giving.

I was stuck on this one part. I said, "God, I do not understand this part about giving my body to be burned. I thought that was the ultimate sacrifice. How much more love could a man walk in?"

It did not take Him long to answer.

Followers of Muhammad have burned themselves alive in protest. They literally poured gasoline on themselves and burned themselves on temple steps. I said, "That is the ultimate sacrifice. How could a man have more love?"

God said to me, "At times it is much harder to be a living sacrifice than a dead martyr."

Think about the apostle Paul when he wrote Philippians. He wrote it from the Tullianum, the prison in Rome hewn out of solid rock where the sewage system ran through. The Philippians were having trouble with strife, so they wrote Paul.

Paul was in prison, up to his waist in human waste, with his arms shackled. Because he was a Roman citizen, he had the right to receive mail and answer it. So they would unshackle him, bring in a candle, and from that condition he wrote Philippians, saying, "Do not be mad at each other. Walk in love. Be nice."

There he was, operating out of pure agape. It would have been much easier to be a dead martyr than the living sacrifice he was at that point for the sake of the Church.

That next step delivers me to agape giving. You cannot operate in agape giving without also giving of yourself. The line is crossed when you are willing to pour out of yourself. That is when you leave phileo behind and begin to enter agape.

Nobody fulfills this chapter without these five steps. If the Holy Ghost does not deliver you there, you are not going.

Jude 19 and 20 says:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit.

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

Those who are sensual are dominated by the carnal appetites of the flesh. They are separated from the people by the flesh and from truth by the flesh. They do not have the operation of the Spirit.

But the next verse says:

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

Building myself up where? Above that sense-dominated mess that causes you to be separated from truth and to live in carnal appetites, malice, hatred, strife, error in doctrine, and error in the way you believe.

You can build yourself up above that sensual, dominated mess on your most holy faith by praying in the Holy Ghost.

How many of you started praying any amount at all in the Holy Ghost and, after a couple of months, hit some kind of snag where it became the hardest thing you could imagine to pray?

I can tell you what happened. God was edifying you to become greater than some problem hindering your walk with Him.

After He edifies you until you are stronger in the spirit than the problem that once ruled you, such as tobacco, screaming at people, anger, or loving money more than God, He turns your attention to the problem.

When He does, it is like putting your whole life under a magnifying glass. You see the problem for the first time for how hideous it is, because your eyes have been edified.

You say, "My God, I cannot believe I am like that." Then you start hating it as much as God hates it.

When you do, God comes on the scene and says, "That is all I needed from you, son, for you to edify yourself to the place where you hate the problem as much as I hate it. You have finally given Me the faith I need to purge you from that thing."

That thing has had hold of you, causing your life to be a straight line downward in God instead of upward, with no conquest and no victory, because the Holy Ghost has not been allowed to be free in your life.

I love you because He made me love you, but there is only so much you can do for me. I love it when you pray for me, but your praying is limited.

When I find the prayer closet and say, "Holy Spirit, You can pray for me today," He says, "You know I am always ready."

I say, "Go ahead."

This is the only gift I can operate in all I want to, anytime I want to. I am the steward of its operation because I am the steward of how edified, how built up past my problems, I want to be.

If I were you, after this afternoon's ministry is over, I would find a corner, crawl into it, and say, "God, pray for me the rest of the afternoon."

"Do you understand what you are saying?"

No, but one day I will, as He builds me up above the problem.